

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Avalanche

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Stay out of avalanche terrain when conditions are unsafe. Read the local avalanche forecast before travel and choose a safer route; rescue equipment does not make a dangerous slope safe. If someone is buried, call rescue and start companion rescue only where you can avoid another avalanche.

Do now.

**Check conditions before departure**

01

Consult the local avalanche center and get training before entering snow-covered backcountry.

**Choose terrain deliberately**

02

Avoid avalanche paths and slopes identified in the forecast; turn around when uncertain.

**Carry and know rescue gear**

03

Each person needs a transceiver, probe and shovel and practiced companion rescue skills.

**If an avalanche occurs**

04

Note the last seen location, call rescue and assess continuing danger before searching.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Without a working phone, prevention and trained companion rescue are even more important. Stay on terrain you have assessed as safe; do not enter a dangerous slope to find reception. Carry a written route and turnaround time with a trusted contact.

Watch for.

Do not enter unstable terrain for an untrained rescue that may create more victims.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area. Decide who helps whom and who carries the essential supplies; do not send a lone child to retrieve items. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: check conditions before departure. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Do not enter unstable terrain for an untrained rescue that may create more victims.

Keep essentials within reach.

For avalanche, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Without a working phone, prevention and trained companion rescue are even more important. Stay on terrain you have assessed as safe; do not enter a dangerous slope to find reception. Carry a written route and turnaround time with a trusted contact. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Take a practical avalanche course and travel with trained partners. Use professional local advice for route selection.

First decision: Check conditions before departure

Consult the local avalanche center and get training before entering snow-covered backcountry. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Without a working phone, prevention and trained companion rescue are even more important. Stay on terrain you have assessed as safe; do not enter a dangerous slope to find reception. Carry a written route and turnaround time with a trusted contact. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Do not enter unstable terrain for an untrained rescue that may create more victims. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Stay out of avalanche terrain when conditions are unsafe. Read the local avalanche forecast before travel and choose a safer route; rescue equipment does not make a dangerous slope safe. If someone is buried, call rescue and start companion rescue only where you can avoid another avalanche. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For avalanche, keep the specific hazard in view: Do not enter unstable terrain for an untrained rescue that may create more victims.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: If an avalanche occurs. Note the last seen location, call rescue and assess continuing danger before searching. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Avalanche · official guidance

<https://www.ready.gov/avalanche>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/avalanche/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.